Narrative Regret, Derivative Suffering And God as the Best Possible Epistemic Ground of Human Dignity

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1.0 Introduction

In this Chapter, I consider the representation of emotional expressions of regret and narrative regret (Goldie 2009). Drawing inspiration from Eleonore Stump's treatment of biblical narrative and a Thomistic account of love, I draw specific attention to the context of the representation of distinct special relationships in fiction. Important here are discourses on the fictional representation of such relationships as a special kind of human agency. I argue that a related concern is the assumption about what is true and what is fiction in popular fiction regarding special relationships, where what is true are expressions of relational sanctification that are grounded in a divine union of love appropriate to friendship.

1.1 Testimonial and Hermeneutic Injustice

According to epistemic standpoint theorists, individuals who hold marginalized positions in western societies are often prevented from contributing to the body of knowledge of their communities (Collins 2005, 2002; Fricker 2006, Saint-Croix 2020). In fact, however, according to epistemic standpoint theorists, these individuals have a lot to contribute by way of their unique vantage point in that community. I consider another form of injustice and argue that the focus on this form obscures even more harmful forms of marginalization. In her book *Wandering in Darkness*, Stump (2010) calls this *Narrative and the Knowledge of Persons*. She understands this in the context of suffering grounded in an inability to form special relationships. The center of this unique form of suffering is a loss of desire for special relationships.

Collins (2009) draws a relational comparison between knowledge and power. The point is that knowledge will enable an individual to obtain what they want out of life. She then argues that historically, knowledge in marginalized communities has been suppressed. What Collins means by suppression of knowledge, however, occurs through the suppression of the intellectual contribution of black women in broader American society. Of course, her concern can be extended to include any individual whose intellectual contribution to the epistemic landscape of the community they reside in has been suppressed.

Namely, the intellectual views of marginalized groups on poverty, oppression, independence etc. However, these knowledge domains, largely influential in formal education, are not central to more important knowledge domains. It is these other knowledge domains that are central to the flourishing of a culture and an individual. The source of these other knowledge domains is first in the home, for it is in the home where we learn who we are, what matters to us, and most importantly, that we are loved and desired. In other words, the source for this other second-personal knowledge exists within the contexts of special relationships.

1.2 Wendy Laybourn's Cost of Being Real

Wendy Laybourn (2018) draws a comparison between black authenticity and what she calls *commodified realness*. According to Laybourn, identity is sold to a broader public as black authenticity. This criticism is centered around the effects of what she calls controlling images in popular media. Of deep concern here, is that many of the members of the communities depicted by such images, consider aspects of these images to be authentic representations of themselves and the communities in which they live. Therefore, there is a public perception that such images are not harmful in themselves. If they are to some degree controlling, then they would be harmful, but there is strong disagreement regarding whether they are (20C History Project 2014; Collins 2006, 2009; Sartwell 1998).

Research on black authenticity identifies commodified black authenticity as "oppressive othering" and "white standards of beauty" as a method of oppressive othering. Here, lighter skin tone is a key component of commercial success in the entertainment industry.

But we must consider too whether rap lyrics are also a case of oppressive othering? By using rap lyrics, Laybourn argues that we can compare oppressive othering with white standards of beauty arguing that each are ways mass media contributes to the further marginalization of minority cultures. However, the way she does so is by drawing attention to a positive correlation between lighter skin tone and higher Billboard chart ratings instead of linking less dominant social classes identified by darker skin tones, with antisocial behavior.

Laybourn follows Nguyen and Anthony (2014) research on black authenticity revealing two trends. The first is commodification when cultural productions of authenticity affect how individuals or cultural products fare in the economic market [p. 771]. The second includes constructing expectations through self-identities. Here a similar relation can be seen between rap lyrics (oppressive othering) and higher chart ratings where higher chart ratings are predicated when an artist meets expectations, the more socially deviant the lyrics, the higher the chart rankings. Laybourn's inclusion of skin color suggests that this expectation is in part physical. However, it is more likely that this expectation is a relational identity, however that is conceived, racially, gender, ethnic, class and income, etc. Further, we ask ourselves how we are meant to identify those who belong to those groups with alternative expectations. Therefore, the center of this issue is that these expectations and identities justify or legitimate membership or exclusion when fulfilled.

Therefore, her suggestion seems to be that a harmful representation of blackness is sold to the public as "authentic blackness" by promoting artists who fit certain physical appearances.

Importantly, this particular commodity then "shapes" what is accepted as authentic blackness, and what is commodified as authentic blackness. However, the application here is that skin tone equates to one's identity. Therefore, here identity is constructed as authentic when the successful signification of what is accepted as "real" or "true" for members of a supposed culture, race, ethnicity, social class. These are individuations of a person's individual identities (a person as an authentic artist) supporting the claim that identity is socially constructed. Therefore, Nguyen et al suggest that the research on "black authenticity" across contexts ought to include varying ideals and expectations which affect "what it means to be black" whether in personal, public, and cultural identities [p. 779]. But this only supports the view that expectations of grounding identity are ones of appearance only.

So, in addition to the "oppressive othering" of cba, "white standards" of beauty are also sold, and it isn't clear what correlation there is between cba and wsb if any. Laybourn argues that both wsb and cba stem from attitudes which position blacks as an out-group and whites as an in-group. I think the focus on beauty standards is distracting from what is truly important about her paper, which are those qualities that we should consider as the essential nature of a person. In other words, we should not think that the color of a person's skin is an essential marker of who they are.

As such, cbas are dangerous when they serve as an avenue for interaction with black culture and a proxy for interpersonal interaction, as evidenced not only by Fanon, but by an entire generation of scholarship around what it means to be black. This is true because they undermine true companionship in that a person is only becoming acquainted with a false image. This image is especially harmful because it is created within a framework "that" that reifies anti-blackness. However, there are two associated harms here, one is the reduction of human identity to a skin color, here it is not only blacks that are harmed, but rather the human person.

There is another concern. In this way, cbas have no bearing on reality, but they take on many seemingly benign forms as well. Of additional concern is that there is a public perception that such images are not in themselves harmful, for instance as evidenced with the centrality of Fanon's literature in academia, perhaps this explains the prevalence of cbas in popular culture, even among those who the images are harming most. An important consequence of this is that many of the members of the communities depicted by such images consider aspects of these images to be authentic representations of themselves and of the communities in which they live and of themselves. Therefore, there is strong disagreement regarding whether they are harmful (20C History Project 2014; Collins 2006, 2009; Sartwell 1998). This second harm is likely related to the first in that by reducing the human person to a skin color, or any other superficial marker of identity, it makes it possible for such cbas to occur in the first place.

In another paper, I highlighted some concerns raised by Wendy Laybourn (2018) regarding representation and authenticity. Here, I want to draw attention to some additional similar concerns. What is important here is that these criticisms unfairly focus too narrowly on the black experience and do not do a good enough job in recognizing that these experiences are universal. Given their universality, I argue that a best response is found in a Christian theodicy of evil as a form of suffering.

Laybourn (2018)'s criticism of black authenticity and what she calls commodified realness is a commodified identity that is sold to a broader public as black authenticity. This criticism is centered around the effects of what she calls controlling images in popular media. Of deep concern here, is that many of the members of the communities depicted by such images consider aspects of these images to be authentic representations and not in themselves harmful. Yet too, this is also a common trope.

I present this case as an example of a paradigmatic concept of hermeneutic injustice. It is not clear just what aspects of the member's lives are represented, nor specifically which images are harmful if such images are accepted as representative. An important question here has to do with the relationship between popular narratives that contain these images, and personal identity. One approach argues that we are defined by the stories we accept about ourselves, but this is controversial and it is the point I will address.

Some similar examples of this criticism can be found in Zakiyyah Iman Jackson (2020) or Mbembe (2017)'s Critique of Black Reason. Jackson (2020) defends the view of race as a social construct. Here black represents a void of reason and a surplus of animality. It is not clear what the counter to this claim should be as it is not represented anywhere in either work. However, looking at what is deemed black culture broadly in popular media, this counter claim is even more difficult to understand given that many African Americans fail to explicitly and publicly criticize, or at the very least, argue that such behaviors are not culturally representative.

One important point made by Collins (2009) is that knowledge is suppressed from black communities. A consequence of this which has not been sufficiently articulated would be if there are examples of this point made by African American thinkers, then given that knowledge is suppressed, public criticisms of the fact that anti-social behaviors are not culturally representative. I suspect however, and this current work is a great attempt to counter this problem, the problem is not that knowledge is suppressed publicly, but that knowledge is suppressed privately in that this understanding that anti-social behavior is not culturally representative, is not being sourced in the home.

Popular artists who reflect similar characteristics as those deemed synonymous to the black race are praised and vaunted. Black female artists for instance, who reinforce stereotypes of blacks as hyper-sexualized, vulgar, using codes such as twerking to exemplify their over hyper-sexualized nature, are praised as empowering or authentic, whereas black male artists are praised as being "real" or "gritty" for expressing unjustified violence directed at other blacks. But this is just to mimic the age-old racist justifications for slavery although slavery, in name, has been outlawed. According to this justification, blackness represents a blurred distinction between humans and animals.

Man distinguishes himself from animality, but this is not the case for the Black Man, who maintains within himself, albeit with a certain degree of ambiguity, animal possibility. A foreign body in our world, he is inhabited under cover—by the animal. To debate Black reason is therefore to return to the collection of debates regarding the rules of how to define the Black

Man: how he is recognized, how one identifies the animal spirit that possesses him, under which conditions the ratio penetrates and governs the animalities (Mbembe 2017, 56).

Unfortunately, while I will not be able to give Professor Stump more of the attention that her book deserves, her view does raise important questions which we must tackle before we can even understand the account of regret I am developing. To do this, we must understand psychic disintegration. Psychic disintegration is necessary to understand why we might think union with another represents diminished health and well-being.

Eleonore Stump (2010) writes on the philosophical problem of evil, arguing that what is truly of concern is not the problem of evil, but rather the problem of suffering. The nature of suffering is essential to her understanding of the problem of evil. Therefore, we must first understand the nature of suffering. It is in suffering that evil is the most pronounced according to Stump.

Here, an important component of suffering is psychological dissolution where one experiences a disintegration of the will. A result of this disintegration is that a person becomes divided from themselves and is no longer able to recognize the desires of their own heart. These desires are ultimately related. As such, the person who has become divided suffers in a state Professor Stump refers to as "willed loneliness", which is a state of psychic disintegration.

Regret is important for Professor Stump's understanding of love. According to her account, love for another is governed by a desire for the good of the loved one, and for union with the loved one. Here, unions are personal rather than physical presence. However, these desires can be undermined by "a person's lack of internal psychic integration" (Stump 2010, 130). When a person is divided against themselves, they are unable to experience desire for the good, or for the personal presence of others. As such, they would be incapable of experiencing regret at the loss of union with another.

According to both Professor Eleonore Stump and Ryan Peterson (2016), Thomas Aquinas develops an ontological account of psychological disintegration grounded in a person's identity. According to both views, a person's identity requires knowledge of who God is to understand who they themselves are. Both accounts argue that this knowledge is built on divine revelation; however, Professor Stump makes two important distinctions. The first is *knowledge-that*, for instance "categorizing on the basis of abstract properties and abstract designations" (Stump 2010, 41) and the second is a *knowledge of persons*, what she calls *second-personal* which is close knowledge of who someone is developed through experience.

. . . populations of mirror neurons in the insula become active both when the test participants experience the emotion and when they see it expressed by others. In other words, the observer and the observed share a neural mechanism that enables a form of direct experiential understanding. (Rizzolatti, Fogassi, and Gallese 2006)

My understanding is that Peterson outlines the argument succinctly in the following manner:

1. According to the Orthodox Christian position, God is ontologically distinct from creation.
2. Therefore, God created humanity to establish an earthly image of Himself in the world.

3. Therefore, humanity is bound to God and God's purposes for creation.
4. But since God created humanity, humanity is a part of his creation.
5. Therefore, God is ontologically distinct from humanity.
6. Therefore, God cannot use humanity to establish an earthly image of Himself in the world.
7. Therefore, humanity is not an earthly image of God in the world.
8. (Some other implications) Therefore, humanity is not bound to God and God's purposes for creation.

The nature of suffering can be drawn from premises 3 and 4. As humans, we often have experiences which align with premise 5. As such, premises 3, 4, and an implicit premise which says that our experiences entail premise 5. It is important to note then that the problem of suffering requires an added premise, that of our experiences. Both accounts then make an important distinction between knowledge gained from experience and other forms of knowledge. In conclusion, both accounts need to be ones that improve knowledge of who we are in relation to our creator. Peterson does this through revelation of one's identity while Professor Stump does this through a second-personal account rooted in narrative and grounded in one's identity.

For my account, regret is an essential mark of this account of identity. If Professor Stump is correct, then we can be taught apt expressions of regret through narratives. Towards the end of this chapter, I will introduce such a theory. First, however, I discuss a number of examples of what relational desire does and does not look like. At the center of Stump's account is the contrast between spiritual health and personal health. There are two ways to understand the correlation of spiritual health with personal health. It first requires that we understand God not as ontologically distinct from humanity, but humanity as an image of God.

In the next section, I first developed a view of humanity using apt and in-apt expressions of regret. I then argue that the in-apt expressions resemble humanity as ontologically distinct from God. I conclude the view with a discussion of what I call relational sanctification.

1.3 Robust and Generic Expressions of Regret and Other Popular Forms of Music

The country music singer George Jones was born September 12, 1931, in Saratoga, Texas. He would die at the age of 81 which is considerable considering the storied life he lived. In the podcast; Cocaine and Rhinestones, and later the book of the same name, Tyler Mahan Coe (2024) dismantles common tropes associated with the singer. Of special importance was Jones' popular marriage to the other country singer Tammy Wynette, which Coe accuses of being an industry publicity stunt, and his marriage to Nancy Pulvado which credits Jones' recovery from drug and alcohol addiction.

The song, "He Stopped Loving Her Today" was completed in 1979 by Bobby Braddock and Curly Putnam, writers for Nashville's Tree Publishing Company (now Sony Music Publishing) (Jones 1979). At least a year prior to its completion, however, George Jones would be told about it by his producer Billy Sherrill. It would go on to become iconic country music from that era. In it, the narrator speaks of a neighbor's dissolution of their relationship. It is never

made clear what kind of relationship it is, whether a legally recognized marriage, friendship, love affair etc. However, what is made manifest throughout the song is its intensity with the narrator expressing that the day his neighbor died, is the first expression of joy he'd seen from the neighbor since his lover left.

Love songs may express regret for those moments prior to the narrator's introduction to the beloved. It is possible that when a song expresses regret for not having met someone sooner, they are thinking about how their life might have gone had they married sooner. Marriage itself is not meaningful for the individual as a stand-alone event. Rather, marriage only has causal influence on the subsequent events of that person's life, and it is the person who defines the event in such a way to make it a meaningful marker of their own identity. It is where marriage sits in the overall context of the course of a given relationship, for instance. A marriage event in the context of a short and harmful relationship has a very different meaning than one in the context of a long and loving relationship. Most importantly, however, it is important in the context of the meaning that a person derives from the event. Many popular songs are saturated in the emotion of regret. In such contexts, the narrative expresses a negative emotion in response to something a character in the narration did, or that was done to them.

In *The Grand Tour* (Jones 1974), the narrator as character expresses regrets at having lost a significant other while the song *He Stopped Loving Her Today*, the narrator, giving a narrative account of someone else also expresses the regret felt by the character when their relationship dissolves. The above are emblematic country songs in that regret is commonly expressed in country music. Different songs express regret in different contexts, however. Apologize by Timbaland is not a country song and expresses regret in a different context. Here the narrator expresses regret for the love that he, the narrator, had felt.

Love songs often express regret when a relationship ends. In the song *The Grand Tour*, our attention is drawn to the daily use of items "where she used to . . ." which speak to the fact that they were once shared by people who experienced positive sentiments toward one another. Their current state however suggests that they are no longer using this way ". . . this old house will never be the same . . .." In *The Grand Tour*, there is existing controversy over whether the end of the relationship is caused by the narrator, or someone else. In the podcast *Cocaine and Rhinestones: The history of country music*, Tyler Mahan Coe suggests that the change in the state of the lives of the individuals involved in *The Grand Tour* is the result of a tragic mishap citing these lines in the song; "There's her rings, all her things, and her clothes are in the closet" and "as you leave you'll see the nursery, . . . taking nothing but the baby and my heart".

The events in The Grand Tour may not have been caused by the involvement of any agent. For instance, if Coe is correct, then the dissolution of the relationship depicted in *The Grand Tour* has nothing to do with any actions committed to the part of the narrator or his lost love. In *He Stopped Loving Her Today*, the regret is more definitively caused by an action when the subject whom the song speaks about is left by their significant other effectively dissolving their relationship. "He said I'll love you 'till I die, she told him 'You'll forget in time' ". Regret can be the result of either an action or an event and the regret in The Grand Tour is likely caused

by an event, whereas in Jones' other song, *He Stopped Loving Her Today*, it is likely caused by an action for instance if the protagonist pursued undisclosed intimate relationships with others.

While in the two previous examples regret is expressed upon the end of a relationship or rather its dissolution, in other examples, more positive emotions, not regret, are expressed upon the end or dissolution of the relationship rather than of the relationship's continuance. For instance, Kelly Clarkson's Since U Been Gone does this: "Since you've been gone, I can breathe for the first time . . .". There are also different reasons for the regret whether expressed for having suffered through the ordeal of that relationship, or for its end. Sometimes the regret is expressed as a longing for various qualities the loved possessed, for instance in the Grand Tour, "over there, sits the chair … and whisper 'oh I love you' ". For these reasons, narratives can help us to feel closeness and union with the loved one even though they are fictional.

Arguably, when a subject experiences this sort of disassociation identified with suffering above, they can no longer experience regret when losing the things most dear to them. This correlates with expressions of emotion associated with love, where love has often been defined as the feeling of loving emotions provoked in one party by another. Upon the object's absence, the subject no longer feels these emotions and experiences of regret on account of this absence (Taylor 1976). The lover can also experience regret in longing for the qualities not possessed by the loved, when someone whom they loved failed to reciprocate in word or deed, or failed in some other way. For instance, in Timbaland's Too Late to Apologize, the following line expresses this: "tell me that you need me then you go and cut me down".

2.0 Identity Reductionism

Narrative accounts of identity attempt to use the way an individual responds to events in a person's life to identify the agent through space and time. For instance, in the agency literature, reductionists explain the metaphysical continuity of an object across space and time in terms of personal identity. Derek Parfit (1987) argues that to understand what sort of object a person is, we need to understand two different qualities. These include the nature of a person and their criterion of identity, i.e., their continued existence over time. But when we consider these qualities in contrast to persons versus non-persons, we include not only physical states of matter, but also immaterial ones such as mental states, memories, beliefs, motivations, etc. A person can be identified just if continuity between subsequent immaterial mental states and physical states are achieved.

Reductionists such as Parfit can define personal identity as the persistence of the human person over time and say that this is reducible to the binding of psychological states with physical matter. A better way to understand this question, however, is through Peterson's account of identity. The Imago Dei as Human Identity Peterson argues provides a response to premise 5 of the imago dei paradox above. Its conclusion is that God is not ontologically distinct from humanity.

There are two ways this can be developed, however. It could conclude with a new understanding of "ontologically".

Or a different understanding of "creation" as it concerns human beings. Ultimately, there is a concern of the difference between:

- God created humanity
- God is distinct from creation

Ontologically then, what we need to understand is what is meant by "God created" and what is the subject of the object which God is said to have created.

Causalism is the most popular account that explains the origin of psychological states, an object A at time T is identical to object B at time T if we can draw a continuous line from object A at time T to object B at time T. The continuous line here is most often mental states such as memory, passions, character traits and dispositions. But often it is the case that those memories we accept as definitive, have their origins in persons or events other than ourselves. There are certain dispositions I have because of persons other than myself signing various documents articulating what rights I recognize as belonging to me for instance.

While Parfit's account does show how persons are not a mere matter, he and other causalists state that an action performed by an agent is an event caused by the mental state of that agent (Altshuler 2021). The difficulty arises in understanding how mental states are related to prior events. While a mental state may be the source of some event, another event may be the source of another mental state. Regardless of the relationship between mental states and the material universe, it is not clear where the causal chain originates.

Korsgaard (1989) has argued that on Parfit (1987)'s account of identity, a person is primarily a *locus of experience* (Korsgaard 1989, 103). This means that the way to identify an object as existing through space and time as it correlates with a person, is by identifying a set of experiences between objects across space and time that are connected through a set of events or some other connecting factor. These events are psychological states and 'spatiotemporally continuous living bod[ies]' (Korsgaard 1989, 104). In this way I might define myself as *an American* and defend such values as independence and freedom. It is plausible then to draw a line from events in 1776, America's founding, to my present day. Therefore, I associate various values I hold with events that transpired in 1776 and as such, the psychological states I currently have, have their own origins centuries before. In other words, because a person's psychological states have prior causes, the states themselves are merely some forms of event and experience.

Narrative accounts are responses to impersonal accounts. According to narrative accounts, how we frame events such as these is what makes the event meaningful for a given individual (Schechtman 1996, 96). Without narratives, the agency and the identity of the subject are lost among a causal chain of events. This has been called 'constitution.' In terms of the constitution model of identity, without the binding effect of narrative, the subject of a given event is victim to a disparate causal chain of cause and effect. Our identity would merely be an impersonal metaphysical continuation of matter (Korsgaard 1996).

Altshuler identifies a problem with the above account, namely that it does not account for those events that are not selected by the agent. He argues that such events do have a causal effect on what ultimately constitutes one's identity. Following Peter Goldberg (2009), Altshuler instead identifies narrative with an agent's *ability* to reconfigure their motivational and psychological past with respect to their own reactions to these events. In other words, Altshuler too, defends a self-constitution model of agency and identity, but one on which a person's responses to his or her past, shape her future identity.

At the center of the difference between popular narratives like those found in popular songs and narrative identity accounts is that popular narratives are merely ones we are prompted to imagine (Gilmore 2020, 132). But the source of narrative identities is not clear. The question then is what connection then is what do those narratives have to those that we are prompted to imagine. John Gilmore (2020) suggests that the relationship is weak and dependent on the function of the imagination for engaging with the work.

One way narrative identity may relate to popular narratives, is if a response is required by the artist that maps onto what an audience perceives as normative. However, Gilmore (2020) rejects this arguing that different popular narratives have different responses. Further, these responses are not justified by normative expressions of emotion, where the emotion elicited by the context is one we would expect outside the popular narrative [p. 132]. Rather, Gilmore defends an intentionalist stance of narrative grounded in normative discontinuity. According to this stance, an author's intentions constrain and justify the emotional response of their audiences. Accordingly, laughter, which would otherwise be inappropriate, would be an apt response to some fiction. It is not clear whether this view can justify one's identification with a racist trope of themselves, however.

Patricia Hill Collins and Wendy Laybourn, on the other hand, suggest a strong relationship (Collins 2006, 2009; Laybourn 2018). The narratives in popular media are controlling images designed to justify racist and sexist attitudes. Controlling images "are designed to make racism, sexism, poverty, and other forms of social injustice appear to be natural, normal, and inevitable parts of everyday life" (Collins 2009, 77).

It is important to point out here that I am not asking about purpose or the design of such prompted imaginings. Rather than focusing on Laybourn's context of 'authenticity' and 'realness' highlights a popular implicit assumption regarding what is true and what is fiction in popular media. Peter Goldberg (2009) highlights our emotions as a form of reflection, especially that of regret. Sometimes as agents, the expression of regret enables one to better exercise their own agency. We can imagine someone being cheated through the purchase of a used car. Looking towards the future, that individual would exercise more caution consequently upon reflection of their mistake. In these moments, the ability to tell a story becomes important as we are enabled by the narrative to recognize the appropriate objects of our emotions in the story. Reflecting on the failed used car purchase, the subject experiences regret. This subsequent experience pushes them to exercise more caution in the future. Similarly, we can compare this to another example. Here, regret is either appropriate to aspects of the story which bear no direct relation to the narrator, or ones that do. Being able to recognize and

reflect on emotions enables one to express their agency going forward. What regret is afforded to the subject when reflecting decisions made by themselves?

In this context, narrative is substantial in our lives. For instance, Michael Bratman has argued that it provides ways of thinking about how our lives may have gone differently or may go differently and why; our plans and how things might turn out (Bratman 2000 and 2018). Thinking in this way leads to regret if we are disappointed in a particular choice we have made. Our feelings of regret can cause us to behave differently in the future. Questions about narrative thinking just are questions about moral agency.

Importantly, the possible prospect of being able to imagine today what a morally good life will look like for us tomorrow, is a question about how what we believe about ourselves today, including what desires we have, influence our ability to pursue these ways of being. These in turn determine our regrets. Imagining what kind of person our spouse will be can perhaps open up some romantic possibilities while closing others. Imagining where we will buy our first home may restrict our career choices, just like imagining how many children we will have may affect where we want to live. But more importantly, having various beliefs about us undergird all these other possibilities.

More importantly, we can develop a sense of agency when we imagine ways in which our friendships, family ties, and other important relationships will go. These are preceded by beliefs in us about ways they *could* go. We can imagine the type of person we are to others and take the necessary steps for becoming that person, if we believe it is possible. As such, the person we will be and how we will relate to others is the goal that is formed by a narrative. Consider one narrative; we imagine ourselves as thoughtful, kind, considerate, loving, or compassionate. Imagining ourselves this way becomes the motivation we need to read up on the latest parenting methods. We might imagine ourselves being invited to witness the birth of a friend's first child and scouring the internet for advice on how to be a better gift giver.

While the argument that the way we imagine our lives going can have a positive causal effect on the kind of person we become, one may argue that this view is too optimistic. To what extent do the experiences we have shape the person we become? For instance, Eric J. Miller (2020) argues that victimhood imposes normative standards that ground the moral status of the victim. What he means is that social roles, such as victims, determine the values we are expected to live by.

As a victim, there are various normative standards imposed on us that undermine our ability to imagine other parenting styles and values, such as those relating to how we protect and nourish our children. Libertarian values may be those we are less apt to promote in our homes. One reason is that when victims as parents, or the parents of victims, instruct a child, they must instruct them to act in self-subordinating ways "when confronted by the police" [221] rather than in ways that assert their autonomy.

Consider the following example narratives:

- Ty Dolla's *by Yourself*: "Stacked your bread and bought your own Mercedes (Vroom, vroom). You your own boss, do it your way (Way)

The song's protagonist is faced with a given environment that forces her to exert her independence rather than her social bonds. As such, her lack of regret is a normative standard imposed on her. We can contrast this situation with the possibility that while material goods may or may not be a necessary condition for well-being, they are certainly not a sufficient one as expressed in other popular songs. The protagonist in the song *Rich and Sad* by Post Malone, looks back over other events, motives, and desires that resulted in the dissolution of his relationship and he feels sadness, as an expression of regret:

- "All this stuntin' couldn't satisfy my soul (–oul), Got a hundred big places, but I'm still alone (–one)".

First, each of the above narratives are constrained by beliefs the narrator may have about themselves. In the first, the narrator, believing they have no other choice but to cut themselves off from anyone who is unable to contribute financially. But it does lead to another criticism, the agency of the artist versus that of the audience. Some music criticisms will often point out that musical taste assumes a sense of moral autonomy not available to some. If an artist is accustomed to abject poverty, then that person might be seen as vulnerable to market forces, creating art that is in high demand for the purposes of financial gain (Laybourn 2018), or only capable of representing their immediate physical environment (Richardson and Scott 2002). Regrets within narratives are an example of such narrative agency. But if Eric Miller is correct, then some populations just do not possess agency in the requisite sense. But this view would thoroughly undermine decades of social justice movements in law and elsewhere.

The common responses to such criticisms come in two forms. They typically make some causal claim about the effects of environment on both artistic performance (Richardson and Scott 2002), and audience music selection criteria, for instance, that artists are merely defining their personal experiences (Shusterman 2007, 419). These responses highlight unequal wealth opportunities imposing normative standards on their victims. The second kind of response makes a cultural claim derived from supposed traditional practices in pre-colonial Africa (Abrahams 2006).

Importantly here, the responses that are grounded in assertions about the culture of pre-colonial Africa are not necessarily a response to the empirical claims about the representations of anti-social behavior in rap and hip-hop music, but rather to the metaphorical use of language exhibited by pre-colonial African tribal practices. What are commonly noted as anti-social themes in rap and hip-hop then are downplayed as wordplay underlying a cultural or political critique or something else entirely. Namely, the references to violence and misogyny are allegorical, not literal (Smitherman 1997; Gates 1989).

Magnus and Malone (2023) give such an account by highlighting the criminal prosecutions that cite song lyrics as testimonial confessions. Malone argues that being too generous in treating artistic assertions as truth in songs, commits the harm of art-interpretive injustice. She

argues that the listener, in this case the prosecution, extends the wrong degree of credibility to the artist. Instead of interpreting the song's lyrics as art, the listener interprets the lyrics as testimony.

Importantly, a component of Malone's argument is that prosecutions do not treat other genres of music based on the content of their art. However, there is another and more important issue at concern here. This worry is found in the dual character account of art Malone has previously defended. There, Malone argues that *authentic* country music is a dual character art-form that embodies "the core value commitments of the genre" (Malone 2023, 1). According to this view, country music, like punk rock and hip-hop (Liao, Meskin, and Knobe 2020) constitute core value commitments. As such, following the dual character account of art, it is not clear what level of credibility we should assign to the song lyrics in criminal prosecutions.

Consider the following dialogue used by Liao, Meskin, and Knobe (2020), 7-8:

The Scientist

Alfie: She is not a scientist. I know many people think she is a scientist, but when you think about what scientists really are, you will realize that she is not a scientist at all.

Betty: Of course she is a scientist. She is skilled at running experiments and publishing in scientific journals.

Alfie: That is not what I meant! What I meant is that she does not possess a genuine willingness to revise her beliefs in light of empirical evidence.

The Christian

Alfie: She is not a Christian. I know many people think she is a Christian, but when you think about what it really means to be a Christian, you will realize that she is not a Christian at all.

Betty: Of course, she is a Christian. She goes to church every week and believes that Jesus is the son of God.

Alfie: That is not what I meant! What I meant is that she does not show genuine compassion.

Malone follows Liao, Meskin, and Knobe (2020) who argue that we can "pick out the concepts" for which people make various judgments as those above, by distinguishing them from the kinds of judgments "from concepts for which people would not make such judgments" (Liao, Meskin, and Knobe 2020, 6). Here, many things will both satisfy and at the same time fail to satisfy the criteria that allow one to make identity judgments. I argue that here, as a character attribution, these concepts enable one to judge whether someone *truly* belongs to a given category.

What is important among these responses, however, is that they too undermine attributions of personal identity and human agency and go against the dual character concept of art. A question they force us to ask; is what songs belong in each category? Separately, some have held that we can determine the values an artist holds, by carefully listening to the song lyrics they write. Although this fact would suggest that an artist's lyrics might qualify as a personal

narrative defining an artist's identity and agency, it is not clear whether such narratives would qualify on this account of narrative agency.

Altshuler's account could give more credence to music lyrics as an example narrative in the psychological sense; it is not clear how this may be the case. According to some accounts, an artist's written lyrics and musical arrangement merely express plausible values someone might hold (Malone 2023), while others articulate them as more definitive (Meissner and Huebner 2022), still others argue that art is functional (Gilmore 2020), thereby leaving open the possibility they could count as narrative in the functional sense, but do not do so necessarily.

For instance, Whyte (2018), Meissner and Huebner (2022) have argued that *settler colonial imaginaries* define what they call *settler* ecologies. These are narratives that replace existing narratives which are pro-social concepts that are central for members of a given community and include beliefs that are central to a group's flourishing. They can include songs that invoke tropes of indigenous identities. Tim McGraw's song *Indian Outlaw* is an example of this sort of practice. In the song, he claims to be half Cherokee and half Choctaw. But it is ambiguous whether he is referring to the character, or if the song is loosely biographical. Either way, it offers a portrait about what it means to be indigenous American. Importantly, however, the song is not aiming at the truth of what it means to be indigenous American. As such, Meissner and Huebner (2022) would argue that it *fortifies the ignorance* of the people and the land that they inhabit. Most importantly, it undermines relational networks between the people that would sustain their *co-flourishing*.

It may be that rap and hip-hop are not good example narratives that sustain co-flourishing. Consider the question above, is some material good a necessary and sufficient condition for well-being as expressed in some popular songs? As narratives, the two examples above would better explain why some events happened. Why the protagonist in *by yourself* severed their relationship with their significant other, and why the protagonist in *Rich and Sad* is rich and sad.

Here, we primarily contrast [money] as the material object expressing that it:

- "could satisfy my soul"

And contrasting this with [money] as the material object expressing that it:

- "could not satisfy my soul".

One way that narratives are thought to explain agency then, is by synchronizing incongruous events, states, and motives. As such, a narrative can say yes; money is either a necessary and sufficient condition for well-being for some agent or not. As such, the expressions of regret offer a plausible way to recognize the core of one's agency.

Recognizing the form of some plausible narratives may help to understand how to recognize a narrative if we say it. The various incidents and events have made it difficult for the agent to recognize value in non-material objects. We can, and often do, ask a meta-ethical question

about what kinds of objects are truly of moral value and why. The narrative provides us with a plausible account of why. For instance, we can ask to what extent the quest for consumer goods ought to outweigh other pursuits such as time with one's children or calling one's mother on Sunday. What is probably missing from the above is the understanding that there is a difference between only some material possession being necessary for well-being, versus some non-material possession being necessary for well-being.

But exactly how are material and non-material objects expressed over and against one another other? It may be the case that volunteering at an orphanage is of moral value, and it can be expressed in song in at least two ways. Lyrically, "I wish I had volunteered at the orphanage yesterday". Or lyrically that expresses a negative outcome for not having volunteered at the orphanage yesterday. In constructing lyrics of the second form, the author chooses words that either have been historically encoded with the sentiment she is hoping to ascribe to a state of affairs, or is potentially encoded with that sentiment in such a way that the desired emotion is potentially ascribed to that state of affairs. However, if I neglect my children in volunteering at an orphanage, then *my* volunteering is of reduced moral value and we could imagine a lyrics saying "I wish I had spent time with my children instead of volunteering at the orphanage yesterday", or that says "I spent so many hours at the orphanage that I do not know who my own children are anymore"; or "I spent hours at the orphanage, I do not know who my own children are anymore".

We can also express a normative question about what behaviors are appropriate, when we should be kind, or whether a given action is more kind than another using similar methods. But there are additional interesting questions. As inferred above, we ask about the context in which a given ethical question is of moral value, and we can express it as a value by inviting the audience to reflect on such expressions by coercing their emotions accordingly. Volunteering my time at an orphanage is of moral value, and so I would use music or poetry to evoke emotions in the audience that correspond with this value. Considering that context is a way to assess the rationality of a given question, emotional expression in art is a way to make sense of that question. Making sense of the question helps us to anticipate the answer in at least two ways. What does the artist suggest is valuable; we would then look at the emotional expressions in her art, and what is the agent potentially capable of valuing.

For instance, assuming that Jill is the last sentient creature on a faraway planet, it may not make sense to ask what Jill's ethical obligations are to those around her. But contexts regarding ethical questions are important. There are two important such contexts here; socio-economic or cultural environments, and psychological or social ones. Given questions about morality, our concerns are largely about how we should behave toward others. For many years, this was answered by referencing cultural and socio-economic conditions. More controversially, it has also been answered by referencing psychological or social conditions. But this is not the same as asking whether a given question about ethical obligation makes sense or not. It would not make sense to say a person with a medical condition that precludes the experience of empathy, has an ethical obligation to experience the emotions that align with empathy. There is a way in which our questions about moral behavior should make sense. This is in the context of our

behavior toward others. Most humans will generally live in contexts wherein our behavior to others should have a kind of rationality about them, in valuing our relationships with others.

The social version of this question is more opaque. It is a question about our social environments and to what extent our social environments can provide us with the resources necessary to fulfill our moral obligations. Once again, there are two categories of questions here. For instance, consider our choices as to what kind of careers would make fulfilling our moral obligations possible. If we recognize a moral obligation to give vast amounts of wealth to charity, then we could pursue a set of social connections (work hard in high school and get into a good university) that would make our ability to fulfill this obligation more likely. The other category of question is even more difficult, however. It begins as a question about us and the sources of our beliefs as to what is possible, and what is not. We would start with a question about what is true about ourselves. Related to this is a question about what extent do those around us contribute to our beliefs about what is true about ourselves and what is obligatory regarding our behavior. If we consider that we have a moral obligation to support national health, then there are some political parties we might campaign on behalf of and others we would not. Here I suggest that how we should understand such questions is in the form of a narrative.

3.0 Summary

In summary, I have argued that controlling images is a form of epistemic suffering and harm. In addition, I have argued that the source of this harm is grounded in a deficient epistemic stance regarding who one is. As such, I argued that the best response to this problem is rooted in a new ontological concept that grounds apt expressions of regret as the proper emotional response to important human relationships. What is not sufficiently articulated is how one forms apt expressions of regret, but I have shown that these can be developed in narratives. What is required, is how these narratives are necessarily ground in one's understanding of who God is, and consequently, who they themselves are.

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